
PO33Q: Determinants of Democracy

Codebook

Dr Florian Linke
Florian.Linke@warwick.ac.uk



Variable	Label
countrycode	Country Code
country	Country Name
year	Year
polity5	Combined Polity V Score
democracy	0 = Autocracy, 1 = Democracy (Miller et al., 2022)
gdppc	GDP per capita (current US Dollars)
gdppc_growth	GDP per capita growth (%)
enrol_gross	School enrollment, primary (% gross)
primcomp	Primary completion rate (% of relevant age group)
primcom_male	Primary completion rate, male (% of relevant age group)
primcom_fem	Primary completion rate, female (% of relevant age group)
enrol_net	School enrollment, primary (% net)
agri	Agriculture, forestry, and fishing, value added (% of GDP)
slums	Population living in slums (% of urban population)
telephone	Households with telephones (Landline & Mobile, %)
internet	Individuals using the Internet (% of population)
tax	Tax revenue (% of GDP)
pop	Population, total
pop_fem	Population, female (% of total population)
electricity	Access to electricity (% of total population)
service	Services, value added (% of GDP)
oil	Oil rents (% of GDP)
natural	Total natural resources rents (% of GDP)
literacy	Literacy rate, adult total (% of people ages 15 and above)
lit_male	Literacy rate, adult male (% of males ages 15 and above)
lit_fem	Literacy rate, adult female (% of males ages 15 and above)
infant	Mortality rate, infant (per 1,000 live births)
health_ex	Current health expenditure (% of GDP)
hospital	Hospital beds (per 1,000 people)
tuberculosis	Incidence of tuberculosis (per 100,000 people)

continued on next page

life	Life expectancy at birth, total (years)
life_male	Life expectancy at birth, male (years)
life_female	Life expectancy at birth, female (years)
unemploy	Unemployed (%)
urban	Urban population, total (% of total population)
attend	Births attended by skilled health staff (% of total)
prenatal	Pregnant women receiving prenatal care of at least four visits
military	Military Expenditure (% of GDP)
un_continent_name	Continent
un_region_name	Region on continent
v2xcs_ccsi	How robust is civil society? Source(s): v2cseeorgs v2csreprss v2csprtcpt
v2cseeorgs	Civil Society – entry and exit
v2csreprss	Civil Society – repression
v2cscnsult	Civil Society – consultation
v2csprtcpt	Civil Society – participatory environment
v2csgender	Civil Society – women’s participation
v2csantimv	Civil Society – anti-system movements
v2csrlgrep	Religious organization repression
v2csrlgcon	Religious organization consultation
v2regsupgroups_0	Regime failure without support: The aristocracy, including high status hereditary social groups and castes
v2regsupgroups_1	Regime failure without support: Agrarian elites, including rich peasants and large landholders.
v2regsupgroups_2	Regime failure without support: Party elites (of the party or parties that control the executive)
v2regsupgroups_3	Regime failure without support: Business elites
v2regsupgroups_4	Regime failure without support: The state bureaucracy
v2regsupgroups_5	Regime failure without support: The military
v2regsupgroups_6	Regime failure without support: An ethnic or racial group(s)
v2regsupgroups_7	Regime failure without support: A religious group(s)
v2regsupgroups_8	Regime failure without support: Local elites, including customary chiefs
v2regsupgroups_9	Regime failure without support: Urban working classes, including labor unions
v2regsupgroups_10	Regime failure without support: Urban middle classes
v2regsupgroups_11	Regime failure without support: Rural working classes (e.g., peasants)
v2regsupgroups_12	Regime failure without support: Rural middle classes (e.g., family farmers)
v2regsupgroups_13	Regime failure without support: A foreign government or colonial power

Table 1: Codebook PO33Q

The data are taken from Coppedge et al. (2025), Marshall and Gurr (2020), Miller et al. (2022), and World Bank (n.d.).

Excerpt from the V-Dem Codebook

These variable specifications are extracted from the Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) Codebook, v15. Full codebook available at v-dem.net.

3.5.1.7 Regime Support Groups (C)

v2regsupgroups

Project Manager(s): Carl Henrik Knutsen

Additional versions: *_nr

Question: Which groups does the current political regime rely on in order to maintain power? (Check all that apply.)

Clarification: Consider which group(s) is supportive of the regime, and, if it/they were to retract support would substantially increase the chance that the regime would lose power.

Responses:

Code	Description	Variable
0	The aristocracy, including high status hereditary social groups and castes.	v2regsupgroups_0
1	Agrarian elites, including rich peasants and large landholders.	v2regsupgroups_1
2	Party elites (of the party or parties that control the executive).	v2regsupgroups_2
3	Business elites.	v2regsupgroups_3
4	The state bureaucracy.	v2regsupgroups_4
5	The military.	v2regsupgroups_5
6	An ethnic or racial group(s).	v2regsupgroups_6
7	A religious group(s).	v2regsupgroups_7
8	Local elites, including customary chiefs.	v2regsupgroups_8
9	Urban working classes, including labor unions.	v2regsupgroups_9
10	Urban middle classes.	v2regsupgroups_10
11	Rural working classes (e.g., peasants).	v2regsupgroups_11
12	Rural middle classes (e.g., family farmers).	v2regsupgroups_12
13	A foreign government or colonial power.	v2regsupgroups_13

Scale	Mean-aggregated scores of dichotomized variable
Answer-type	Multiple-selection
Data release	9–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Mean
Cleaning	Set to missing where v2regint is 0
Years	1789–2023
Default date	January 1

Citation: V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

3.11 Civil Society

Instructions to coders: Civil society organizations (CSOs) include interest groups, labor unions, religiously inspired organizations (if engaged in civic or political activities), social movements, professional associations, and classic NGOs—but not businesses, political parties, government agencies, or religious organizations primarily focused on spiritual practices. A CSO must be at least nominally independent of government and economic institutions.

Historical clarification: If no CSOs exist at all for a particular time period, code the relevant questions as giving the lowest score (indicating, e.g., strong repression or no consultation, a 0).

Religious organizations: Two questions in this section address religious organizations, which may be religiously inspired CSOs or organizations whose purpose is primarily spiritual.

3.11.1 General

3.11.1.1 CSO Entry and Exit (C)

v2cseeorgs

Project Manager(s): Michael Bernhard

Additional versions: *_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr

Question: To what extent does the government achieve control over entry and exit by civil society organizations (CSOs) into public life?

Responses:

	Code	Description
	0	Monopolistic control. The government exercises an explicit monopoly over CSOs. The only organizations allowed to engage in political activity are government-sponsored. The government actively represses those who attempt to defy its monopoly.
	1	Substantial control. The government licenses all CSOs and uses political criteria to bar organizations likely to oppose it. At least some citizen-based organizations play a limited independent role. The government actively represses those who flout its political criteria.
	2	Moderate control. Whether the ban on independent CSOs is partial or full, some prohibited organizations manage to play an active political role. The government does not or cannot repress them.
	3	Minimal control. Constitutional provisions allow the government to ban organizations with a history of anti-democratic action (e.g., banning of neo-fascist or communist organizations in the FRG). Such banning takes place under strict rule of law and judicial independence.
	4	Unconstrained. The government does not impede CSO formation and operation unless they are engaged in activities to violently overthrow the government.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

3.11.1.2 CSO Repression (C)

v2csreprss

Project Manager(s): Michael Bernhard

Additional versions: *_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr

Question: Does the government attempt to repress civil society organizations (CSOs)?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	Severely. The government violently pursues all real and even some imagined members of CSOs, seeking to effectively liquidate them. Examples: Stalinist Russia, Nazi Germany, Maoist China.
1	Substantially. The government arrests, tries, and imprisons leaders and participants in oppositional CSOs who have acted lawfully. Other sanctions include disruption of gatherings and violent sanctions. Examples: Mugabe's Zimbabwe, Poland under Martial Law.
2	Moderately. The government engages in minor legal harassment (detentions, short-term incarceration) and may restrict association or block international contacts. Examples: post-Martial Law Poland, Brazil in the early 1980s.
3	Weakly. The government uses material sanctions (fines, firings, denial of social services) and burdensome registration procedures. May organize GONGOs. Example: Putin's Russia.
4	No. CSOs are free to organize, associate, strike, express themselves, and criticize the government without fear of sanctions or harassment.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

Note: As of December 2014, responses are reversed so that 0 = least democratic, 4 = most democratic.

3.11.1.3 CSO Consultation (C)

v2cscnsult

Project Manager(s): Michael Bernhard

Additional versions: *_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr

Question: Are major civil society organizations (CSOs) routinely consulted by policymakers on policies relevant to their members?

Responses:

	Code	Description
	0	No. High degree of insulation from CSO input. The government may mobilize CSOs after policies are adopted but does not consult them in formulating policies.
	1	To some degree. CSOs are but one set of voices that policymakers sometimes take into account.
	2	Yes. Important CSOs are recognized as stakeholders in important policy areas. This can be accomplished through formal corporatist or less formal arrangements.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

3.11.1.4 CSO Structure (C)

v2csstruc

Project Manager(s): Michael Bernhard

Additional versions: *_nr

Question: Characterize the relative influence of large mass constituency CSOs versus smaller, more local, or narrowly construed CSOs.

Responses:

	Code	Description	Variable
	0	The state does not allow autonomous CSOs.	v2csstruc_0
	1	Large encompassing organizations dominate. Government and CSOs are linked through corporatism; particular large CSOs are highly influential.	v2csstruc_1
	2	Neither large nor small CSOs dominate. Influence is contingent on circumstances; organizations of both sizes contend with one another.	v2csstruc_2
	3	Small CSOs dominate. Many small organizations contend to have their voices heard.	v2csstruc_3

Scale	Mean-aggregated scores of dichotomized variable
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Mean
Years	1789–2024

3.11.1.5 CSO Participatory Environment (C)

v2csprtcpt

Project Manager(s): Michael Bernhard

Additional versions: *_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr

Question: Which of these best describes the involvement of people in civil society organizations (CSOs)?

Responses:

	Code	Description
	0	Most associations are state-sponsored; participation is not purely voluntary.
	1	Voluntary CSOs exist but few people are active in them.
	2	There are many diverse CSOs, but popular involvement is minimal.
	3	There are many diverse CSOs and it is considered normal for people to be at least occasionally active in at least one.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

3.11.1.6 CSO Women’s Participation (C)

v2csgender

Project Manager(s): Michael Bernhard

Additional versions: *_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr

Question: Are women prevented from participating in civil society organizations (CSOs)?

Clarification: Consider both (A) whether women are prevented from participating in CSOs because of their gender and (B) whether CSOs pursuing women’s interests are prevented from taking part in associational life.

Responses:

Code	Description
0	Almost always.
1	Frequently.
2	About half the time.
3	Rarely.
4	Almost never.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

3.11.1.7 CSO Anti-System Movements (C)

v2csantimv

Project Manager(s): Michael Bernhard

Additional versions: *_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr

Question: Among civil society organizations, are there anti-system opposition movements?

Clarification: An anti-system opposition movement is any movement—peaceful or armed—that is based in the country (not abroad) and is organized in opposition to the current political system. It aims to change the polity in fundamental ways (e.g., democratic to autocratic, capitalist to communist, secular to fundamentalist). It may be linked to an electoral party but must have a mass base and existence separate from normal electoral competition.

Responses:

Code	Description
0	No, or very minimal. Anti-system movements are practically nonexistent.
1	Low-level activity; does not pose much threat to the regime.
2	Modest level of activity, posing some threat to the regime.
3	High level of activity, posing substantial threat to the regime.
4	Very high level of activity, posing a real and present threat to the regime.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024
Convergence	Issues with universal thresholds

Ordering: If coded “0”, skip the following questions on anti-system movements.

3.11.1.8 CSO Anti-System Movement Character (C)

v2csanmvch

Project Manager(s): Michael Bernhard

Additional versions: *_nr

Question: How would you characterize the anti-system movement(s) identified in the previous question? (Check all that apply.)

Responses:

Code	Description	Variable
0	Works through legal channels, for the most part.	v2csanmvch_0
1	Participates in elections.	v2csanmvch_1
2	Works through a mix of legal and extra-legal channels.	v2csanmvch_2
3	Insurrectionary.	v2csanmvch_3
4	Democratic. Perceived as willing to play by democratic rules, respect constitutional provisions, and relinquish power.	v2csanmvch_4
5	Anti-democratic. Perceived as unwilling to play by democratic rules or relinquish power.	v2csanmvch_5
6	Leftist, socialist, communist.	v2csanmvch_6
7	Rightist, conservative, party of order.	v2csanmvch_7
8	Ethnolinguistic, tribe, kinship, clan.	v2csanmvch_8
9	Separatist or autonomist.	v2csanmvch_9
10	Religious.	v2csanmvch_10
11	Paramilitary.	v2csanmvch_11
12	Heavily engaged in criminal activity (e.g., narcotics, extortion, kidnapping).	v2csanmvch_12

Scale	Mean-aggregated scores of dichotomized variable
Answer-type	Multiple-selection
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Mean
Years	1789–2024

3.11.1.9 Religious Organization Repression (C)

v2csr1grep

Project Manager(s): Michael Coppedge

Additional versions: *_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr

Question: Does the government attempt to repress religious organizations?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	Severely. The government violently pursues all real and even some imagined members of religious organizations, seeking to liquidate them. Examples: Stalinist Russia, Maoist China.
1	Substantially. The government arrests, tries, and imprisons leaders and participants who acted lawfully. Includes disruption of gatherings and violent sanctions.
2	Moderately. Minor legal harassment (detentions, short-term incarceration); may restrict association or block international contacts.
3	Weakly. Material sanctions (fines, firings, denial of services); burdensome registration; may organize parallel religious organizations.
4	No. Religious organizations are free to organize, associate, strike, express themselves, and criticize the government without fear of sanctions.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

3.11.1.10 Religious Organization Consultation (C)

v2csr1gcon

Project Manager(s): Michael Coppedge

Additional versions: *_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr

Question: Are major religious organizations routinely consulted by policymakers on policies relevant to their members?

Responses:

	Code	Description
	0	No. High degree of insulation from religious organization input. The government may mobilize them after policies are adopted but does not consult them in formulating policies.
	1	To some degree. Religious organizations are but one set of voices that policymakers sometimes take into account.
	2	Yes. Important religious organizations are recognized as stakeholders in important policy areas, through formal or informal arrangements.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

List of References

- Coppedge, M., Gerring, J., Knutsen, C. H., Lindberg, S. I., Teorell, J., Altman, D., Angiolillo, F., Bernhard, M., Cornell, A., Gjerløw, H., Glynn, A., Grahn, S., Hicken, A., Kinzelbach, K., Marquardt, K., McMann, K., Mechkova, V., Medzihorsky, J., Neundorf, A., ... Sundström, A. (2025). V-dem dataset v15. <https://doi.org/10.23696/VDEMDS25>
- Marshall, M. G., & Gurr, T. R. (2020). Polity V Project: Political Regime Characteristics and Transitions, 1800–2018 [Available online at <https://www.systemicpeace.org/inscr/p5manualv2018.pdf>].
- Miller, M., Boix, C., & Rosato, S. (2022). *Boix–Miller–Rosato Dichotomous Coding of Democracy, 1800–2020*. <https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/FENWWR>
- World Bank. (n.d.). World Development Indicators. <https://datacatalog.worldbank.org/dataset/world-development-indicators>